

Disruption S-Curves

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Incumbent vs. entrant trajectories

PROFESSIONAL DEFINITION

Disruption S-Curves plot the performance trajectories of incumbent and entrant technologies over time, showing how an initially inferior entrant can overtake an incumbent as its curve steepens.

WHO DEVELOPED IT

Rooted in technology-S-curve analysis (Foster) and central to Clayton Christensen's theory of disruptive innovation.

WHY IT WAS DEVELOPED

It was developed to explain how disruptors that start below incumbents' performance can eventually surpass them, often unnoticed until too late.

FIGURE 1 · DISRUPTION S-CURVES

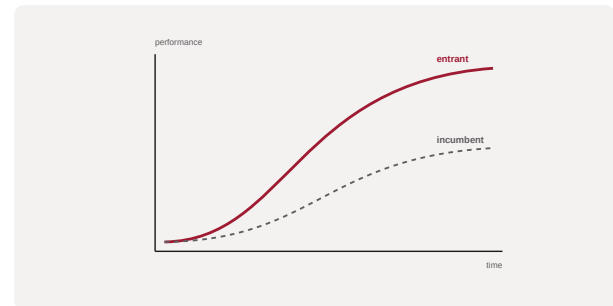


Figure 1. A schematic of the Disruption S-Curves as applied in BARBM312 (illustrative).

HOW IT IS USED

Incumbent and entrant trajectories are plotted; the crossover point and the incumbent's vulnerability are assessed.

WHEN IT IS USED

When analysing disruptive threats and timing strategic responses.

BY WHOM IT IS USED

Strategists, innovation leaders and executives.

INNOVATION RELATIVE TO THE PREDECESSOR TOOL

It visualises why good firms miss disruption — they track the wrong curve — underpinning the Innovator's Dilemma.

RELATED FRAMEWORKS IN THIS COURSE

Innovator's Dilemma · Slibrary 18

Three Horizons of Growth · Slibrary 18

Adjacent Possible Map · Slibrary 18

Disruption Vulnerability Audit · Slibrary 18

SOURCES (HARVARD REFERENCING STYLE)

Foster, R.N. (1986) Innovation: The Attacker's Advantage. New York: Summit.

Christensen, C.M. (1997) The Innovator's Dilemma. Boston: HBS Press.